

accounts or plan for the future because it was “too stressful” and I was “too fragile right now.”

---

My first “breakdown” took place in 2008 when I was a sophomore in college. I had become too anxious to eat, and so I was stick thin and shaking constantly. I don’t fully remember how that episode ended but all I know is (1) in photos of myself from back then, I am pale and sickly (in one set, I’m on the beach with my friends and my legs look like knobby toothpicks) and (2) I never did anything to fix it. I waited it out and kept working myself to death at my *Globe* job and at school (the newspaper, the honors program, classes). Just like my money troubles, my mental health was a pattern I was staving off instead of treating. I didn’t go on meds then because the idea never occurred to me. The anxiety eventually became more manageable, and I convinced myself it was a fluke.

Four years later, in May 2012, I crashed again. This was the second time I’d gone from intense manic work ethic to crushing suicidal depression in the course of one year, but I still didn’t understand that my brain chemistry might be to blame.

When it happened in 2012, I’d been riding high—so high, in fact, that although I didn’t have any health insurance, I decided to undergo minor surgery to correct a broken blood vessel on my lower lip. It was a purely cosmetic choice. My pink lips had a small red dot on them that had been there for years and caused me no physical pain. I became fixated on it, thinking it made me ugly. (Other people barely noticed it.)

I went to an outpatient surgeon my grandmother recommended who said he could laser the blood vessel’s coloration back to pink for a few thousand dollars I didn’t have. I put it on my credit card and got the surgery. I honestly do not know what I was thinking. I just got the idea in my head that I *needed* to fix this little dark spot and that once I did, everything in my life would fall into place. I procured a bunch of medical debt for no apparent reason. The crash was coming at me like a shark with the *Jaws* theme song playing behind him.